Your Creative Path

A plan for Erica, built from your own answers

Short term · Medium term · Longer term

This isn't a test, and there's no way to fall behind on it. It's a starting map. You set the pace, and it's meant to change as you learn what you like.

October 2026

What your answers told us

You've already done things a lot of people only talk about doing:

- Over **50 paintings**, and people have **paid you** for them.
- People have **paid you for social media content**.
- Real acting experience in **local stage plays**.
- A microphone and recording gear, so you're **already set up for voice work**.
- A rare combination: you're **very creative and very analytical**, and you love art, music *and* science.

What you told us you want, and don't want

Yes: full-time income within about 2 years. Health insurance through work. Your work is seen, not your face. Working mostly on your own, or alongside one other person. Freedom over *how* you do things. Remote work, or moving if it's the right move.

No: promoting yourself on social media. Cold calling. Rigid briefs that box you in.

Your answers are what shaped this plan.

Because rigid briefs stress you out, the plan looks for work where someone else sets the *goal* and you choose the *method*. Research on creativity backs this up: most people do their best creative work that way. Because you don't want to sell yourself, every path here has someone else bring the work to you: an employer, a recruiter, a casting roster or a publisher.

The big idea: two tracks

Track 1: A job that pays the bills (and gives you health insurance). Its only job is a steady paycheck. It is *not* where you have to prove anything.

Track 2: A creative build, at your pace. Small experiments to find out what you actually enjoy, before you spend money or years on anything.

Most working artists don't earn their living from selling their own art. They earn it from creative jobs and contract work. A paycheck job isn't giving up. It's how the long game is usually played.

SHORT TERM

The next 3 to 6 months

Get steady income in place and start two small experiments

Track 1: Find a paycheck job with benefits

Best fit: a digital content or multimedia job at a hospital or health system, a university, or a science museum or nonprofit. These jobs often accept an associate's degree or equivalent experience, usually include health insurance, and your paid content work counts. They also put you near science.

Also: sign up with **Aquent / Vitamin T**, a creative staffing agency. Their recruiters bring jobs to you, so you never have to cold call. Ask them directly what health coverage they offer.

> **Skip jobs that:** put you on camera, ask you to fill in on air, are mostly photography, or are "remote editor" gigs that turn out to be AI-training work.

Backup if money gets tight: hospital **patient registration** (hired within weeks, and your business degree helps) or **sterile processing** (about 4 months of training, mostly behind the scenes, with hospital benefits).

Track 2: Two small creative experiments

Try each one for about two weeks, a few hours a week. You're not trying to be good at it yet. You're finding out how it *feels*.

Experiment A: Voice and audio

Take ACX's free audiobook narrator training. Record a 5-minute reading on your own mic. Try proofing one chapter (listening for mistakes).

Experiment B: Science visuals

Do one free Tableau Public tutorial. Then make one chart or graphic from real science data (NASA, NOAA or the CDC all publish it free).

A three-line daily note (one minute, tops): What moved forward today? Did I lose track of time? Did anything drain me? After 90 days, these notes will show you which direction you enjoy more.

Painting stays yours. It's not a product and not a test. Paint when you want to.

Your first 90 days

Weeks 1–3	One résumé that presents your paid content work as real experience. One portfolio of 8–12 pieces (paintings, content work, a voice sample). Sign up with Aquent. Make a short list of places you'd like to work.
Weeks 2–10	Send a few applications a week, on a day and time you pick. Run the two experiments, one at a time.
Day 60	A quick check-in. No interviews yet? Tweak the résumé and widen the search. Money tight? Start on the backup jobs too.
Day 90	Look back together, however you'd like. Which experiment did you enjoy more? Pick one direction for the next six months.

MEDIUM TERM

About 6 months to 2 years

Settle into steady work and grow the direction you picked

By now you'll ideally have a steady job with benefits. You'll also know which experiment felt better. Then you follow **one** of these directions. You don't have to do both.

If voice and audio felt right

- Narrate audiobooks on ACX (Audible's marketplace for narrators) as side income. You audition for books that are posted, so there's no selling yourself. Human narrators still earn almost all audiobook revenue; AI-narrated books are a tiny fraction.
- Learn audio cleanup software (iZotope RX, about $300) and take on paid editing and proofing for other narrators.
- If moving is on the table, in-house audiobook jobs (proofing, quality control, production assistant) come with benefits.

If science visuals felt right

- Take a low-cost course: the Tableau certification (about $100) or Google Data Analytics (about $150–300).
- Build a small collection of 5–8 science graphics and charts, on topics *you* find fascinating.
- Use your content job to move toward science communication work: graphics, explainers, visuals for researchers.

Along the way, only if you want to

- Around year two, an **art licensing agent** could license your paintings or patterns onto products. The agent does the selling, not you.
- If the job's insurance makes it affordable, **a therapist** who works with the inner critic can be a real ally. Look for Compassion-Focused Therapy or ACT. This is completely optional and isn't a condition of the plan.

LONGER TERM

2 to 5 years

Bigger doors that open once you've built a track record

These are where the short- and medium-term steps lead. None of them have to be decided now.

Data and science visual communication

Turning science and data into clear, beautiful visuals. It uses both your analytical and creative sides. Most people in this field are employees, about half work fully remote, and typical pay is around $80,000–100,000 a year.

Audiobook narration and audio production

Steady narration and editing work through publishers and production companies. It's solitary and creative, and it uses your voice and acting.

Game audio (a stretch goal)

Building the sound for video games. It's the best-paid of the audio paths and mixes art, music and science, but it takes about 3–5 years to break into.

Scientific illustration

Probably the closest match to everything you love. Most staff jobs want a bachelor's degree. If you ever want that door, you could finish one online while working (WGU and SNHU both build on an associate's).

Radiologic technology: a backup, not a side job

This turned out to be a much bigger commitment than "a little money": science prerequisites, a competitive application and about two years of full-time training. The payoff is real, though: a median of about $80,000, and the option later to work 2–3 shifts a week with benefits. It's worth reconsidering around late 2028 if the creative path has stalled.

And always: painting stays yours, *whatever else you do.*

When it feels hard

Putting things off is very common, especially for creative people. Research shows it's usually not laziness. Usually a task feels uncomfortable, and avoiding it brings quick relief. So the fix isn't more pressure. It's making the next step feel safer.

Shrink the step. If you're stuck, the step is too big. "Apply for jobs" becomes "open the job site and read one posting."

Decide when, ahead of time. "If it's Tuesday after lunch, I send one application." This kind of if-then plan is one of the best-supported tools there is.

Forgive the slip. People who go easy on themselves after a bad day procrastinate *less* the next time, not more.

You choose your feedback. Feedback on your creative work comes only when you ask for it, and only from one or two people you trust.

Count small wins. Making progress on something that matters, even a little, is the biggest driver of a good day. That's what the three-line note is for.

Keep some art just for you. Not everything you make has to earn money or be shown to anyone.

> **How Marcus can help:** handling practical things like logistics and looking over applications if you ask, and cheering you on. He's on your side, not grading your work. Any check-ins happen the way *you* set them up.

Everything on one page

	Track 1: Paycheck	Track 2: Creative
Short term 0–6 months	Content or multimedia job at a hospital, university or science nonprofit. Sign up with Aquent. Backup: patient registration or sterile processing.	Two two-week experiments: voice/audio and science visuals. Three-line daily note. Paint freely.
Medium term 6 months–2 years	Settle into a job with benefits. Move toward work closer to your chosen direction.	Follow *one* direction: audiobook narration and editing, *or* a science-graphics collection plus a low-cost course. Optional: a licensing agent, a therapist.
Longer term 2–5 years	A full-time creative role: science visual communication, or audiobook and audio production. Backup: radiologic technology.	Stretch goals: game audio, scientific illustration (with an online bachelor's). Painting stays yours.

You don't have to believe in yourself all at once to follow this plan. You only have to take the next small step, and let the evidence pile up.

Pay figures and program details come from research done in October 2026. Check details like health coverage directly with employers before deciding. Full sources are in the research report.